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Few Charles high schoolers pass Algebra I test

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Oct 15, 2025



Kevin Lowndes, left, chief of teaching and learning at the Charles public schools system, and district administrators summarize the district's Maryland Comprehensive Assessment Program scores and district initiatives to monitor learning during the Charles school board of education meeting on Sept. 9.

Screenshot by Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

This is the first of a two-part series looking at Charles public schools' state standardized test results.

Only one in 20 high school students enrolled in Algebra I last school year passed the state's standardized test for that class.

The school district scored an average of 9.1% for Algebra I with the state average at 21.4% on the state Algebra I test, according to data from the Maryland State Department of Education. The average also includes middle school students who were enrolled in Algebra I during the 2024-2025 school year.

The Maryland Comprehensive Assessment Program, or MCAP, provides information to educators, families and the public on student progress toward proficiency on the Maryland state content standards.

Students in grades 3-8 and Grade 10 take English assessments, students in grades 3-8 and those taking Algebra I take a math assessment while students in fifth and eighth grade take a science assessment. There is also an Algebra II and Geometry assessment for middle and high school students.

Students take a local math assessment after every unit in class whereas the state's MCAP tests are a cumulation of the year, Kevin Lowndes, chief of teaching and learning at the Charles public schools system, said. To help with the Algebra I scores, the district is having students practice more of a compilation of material rather than just the unit assessments.

The district continues to track and monitor student progress and provide resources to help students move toward proficiency, Superintendent Maria Navarro said during a school board meeting last month.

"While we fall behind a bit on state averages, in many ways Charles County is growing at a faster rate than the state," Navarro said during the Sept. 9 meeting.

"We're moving in an upward bound direction towards more students demonstrating proficiency."

Students struggle the most with questions that have multiple answers and steps, Lowndes said. The district is trying to get students to read the question then answer multiple steps to that question.

For math, all grade levels saw a rise over the previous year except for Algebra I and eighth grade, according to a release from Charles public schools. The district average for the Algebra I 2023-2024 MCAP assessment was 9.9%.

MCAP gives families a snapshot on how students and kids are performing at a particular school in a particular time, but it does not tell the whole story, Pascale Small, a Waldorf resident and founder of the parent-led organization Charles County Rise, said.

“We have no time to waste,” Small, who ran for a seat on the Charles board of education in 2024 and lost, said. “The numbers are still not great. It’s nothing to celebrate.”

The Charles school system’s “Mutli-Tiered System of Supports” looks at when a student is struggling through core instruction and puts plans in place to help them, Lowndes said.

Elementary schools developed plans for students that are below grade level in reading and math then provide specific interventions. The system has been offered in previous years, but it’s the district’s first time monitoring it from the central office level.

For instance, if a student is struggling with fractions, a teacher will do additional assessments to determine if this is a one-time thing or if there is a pattern, Navarro told Southern Maryland News. After four to six weeks, if the student is still struggling, the teacher will do a more intense intervention.

Collaborative planning is an opportunity for teachers to plan their lessons together and then assess how the lessons went, Navarro said. By learning how other teachers plan their lessons or use resources, teachers can help students on the tests.

“That is part of the way we should function as educators,” Navarro said. “You feed off each other’s strengths, you inform each other’s work and you learn from each other.”

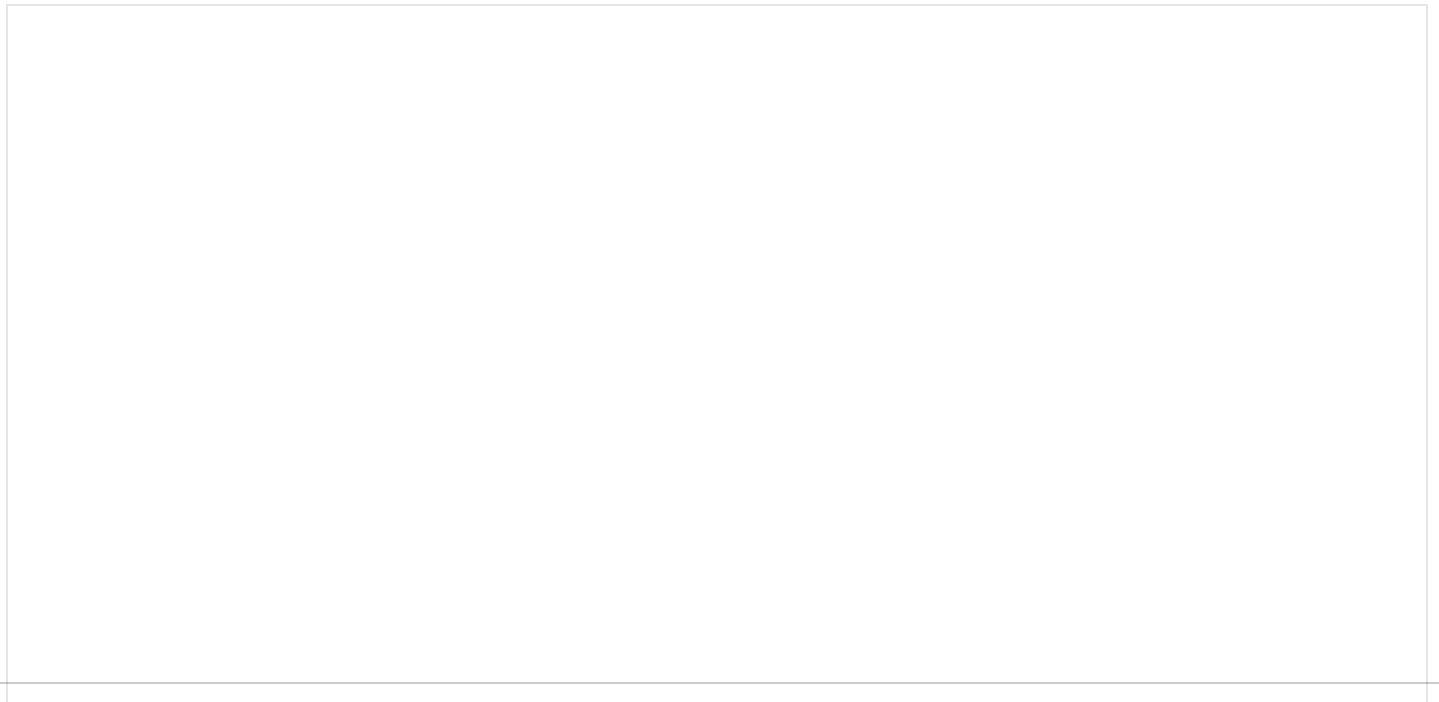
The school district talks about using different protocols to facilitate collaborative planning four times a year, Navarro said. It looks at student work and assesses what students were able to do, what they know and what they didn’t learn.

The district also needs more interventionists in schools because there are “too many children behind that need to be pulled out with an adult who is properly trained,” Small said.

“We have children at those higher level grades who aren’t reading and comprehending and doing math at the level they need to,” Small said. “You need to have someone in the classroom that actually knows what they’re doing.”

But the increased achievement among students is the “result of a continued targeted focus on the individual learning needs of all students,” Navarro said in a release.

“This data shows us that across the school system, more students are mastering grade-level content,” Navarro said. “We see the increase rise slightly in math as students progress toward middle school.”



CHARLES PUBLIC SCHOOLS' MCAP ALGEBRA SCORES

Charles public schools generally showed lower proficiency rates than the state average in all test scores.

 District scores  State scores



Individual school scores*

Henry E. Lackey HS	5%
La Plata HS	5%
Maurice J. McDonough HS	5%
North Point HS	5.8%
St. Charles HS	5%
Thomas Stone HS	5%
Westlake HS	5%

*The percentage for the math category is ≤ 5 and the corresponding counts have been suppressed.



Charles public schools' algebra scores
Meghan Sasser Oct 14, 2025